9 Agreement of Verb with Subject

Revision

A sentence is a group of words that contains a *finite verb* and a *subject*, and makes complete sense by itself—it does not depend on any other word or group of words to do so.

In Book 3, we have learnt a little about two kinds of verbs: *finite* verbs and *infinitives*.

We have seen that a finite verb agrees with its subject in number: if the subject is singular, the verb has to be singular; if the subject is plural, the verb has to be plural.

This is known as the *agreement of a verb with its subject*. This is a very important matter, and we shall look at it a little more closely in a short while.

A finite verb also has tense.

An infinitive is not directly linked to a subject, and, therefore, is not controlled by a subject in any way. A simple infinitive, as described below, has no tense.

An infinitive can be of two kinds:

1. to- infinitive: *He wanted to write a letter to his friend.*
   (wanted—finite; to write—to- infinitive)
2. bare infinitive: *He helped me finish the task.*
   (helped—finite; finish—bare infinitive)

A ***Pick out the verbs from the following sentences and say which are finite and which simple infinitives:***

1. The cold wind made us shiver.
2. The loud roars of the lions made the child tremble with fear.
3. Arjun likes to play with his friends.
4. It is easy to make promises, but difficult to keep them.
5. Our teacher told us to come early to school today.

The Subject

You have seen how a sentence can be broadly divided into two parts:

(i) the *subject* and (ii) the *predicate*.

The sentences given below can be divided into subject and predicate as shown in the table that follows:

(a) The dog sleeps on the sofa.

(b) John and Jeff were good friends.

(c) A brave young man saved us from danger.

(d) We went on a holiday.

Subject	Predicate
(a) The dog	*sleeps on the sofa*
(b) John and Jeff	*were good friends*
(c) A brave young man	*saved us from danger*
(d) We	*went on a holiday*

The predicate contains the finite verb: *sleeps, were, saved, went*.

You know that the subject of the verb can be found by asking the question: *who/what* + the predicate?

(a) Who + sleeps on the sofa? Ans: (The) *dog*

(b) Who + were good friends? Ans: *John* (and) *Jeff*

(c) Who + saved us from danger? Ans: (A brave young) *man*

(d) Who + went on a holiday? Ans: *We*

So, the subjects of the verbs—*sleeps, were, saved, went*—are: (The) *dog, John* (and) *Jeff,* (A brave young) *man, We*.

If we now look closely at the subjects, we find that they are made up of:

1. A noun/nouns/a word or group of words which does the work of a noun: *dog* (a noun); *John, Jeff* (nouns); *man* (a noun); *We* (a pronoun which does the work of a noun).
2. One or more words which tell us something about the noun/nouns/the word or words doing the work of a noun:

In *(a)*, the subject includes the definite article *The* which is used to refer to a particular *dog*.

In *(b)*, the subject includes the conjunction *and* which has been used to join two proper nouns: *John, Jeff*.

In *(c)*, the subject includes the indefinite article *a* and two adjectives: *brave, young*.

So, in all these examples, we find that we are really talking about *dog, Jeff, John, man, We*. In other words, the most important word or words of the subjects are: *dog, John, Jeff, man, We*.

Such a word or words are known as the ***subject-word, subject-words*** or the ***simple subject***. Other words, included in the subject—*The, and, A brave young*—just tell us more about the simple subject.

To avoid confusion, from now on we shall use the word *subject* to refer to the simple subject.

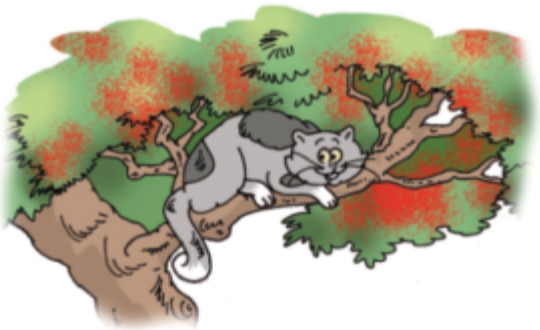
Similarly, we shall use the word *verb* to refer to a finite verb.

B ***Pick out the finite verbs and their subjects from the following sentences. Use a table like the one given below. An example has been given to help you.***

Vishal and his parents live in England.

Subject	Verb
Vishal, parents	*live*

1. The policeman asked him his name and address.
2. The little children of the nursery classes held a Christmas party in their school.
3. The three wise men of the East brought gifts for the infant Jesus.
4. A big cat was sitting on the branch of a tree.
5. The nearest shop was three miles away.
6. The old man sat down on the bench to rest.
7. A brave warrior will fight to the last.
8. A black spider lives behind the bathroom mirror.
9. A wounded tiger often becomes a maneater.
10. The kind prince decided to become a monk.



Since the subject of a sentence is a noun or group of nouns, or a word or group of words acting like a noun, the subject of a sentence can be a pronoun or a group of pronouns. Remember also that all common nouns and proper nouns are treated as pronouns of the third person.

So, now we can go a step further and say that a finite verb must always agree with its subject in (i) number and (ii) person.

What (i) means has already been explained to you: if the subject is singular, the finite verb, of which it is the subject, must be singular; if the subject is plural, the finite verb, of which it is the subject, must be plural.

What (ii) means is that the form of the finite verb will depend on the person of the subject:

(e) *I am singing.*
(f) *We are singing.*
(g) *He/She sings.*
(h) *They sing.*
(i) *You sing, too.*
(j) *Govinda sings.*
(k) *Some birds sing.*
(l) *A cat mews.*

In *(e)*, the subject *I* is first person singular. So, the verb is first person singular—*am singing*.

> The first person *I* behaves a little unusually. We say:
>
> I *am* a student, I *am going* home, I *was going* home.
>
> So, in all these cases *I* takes a singular verb: *am, am going, was going*. Note that *am* and *was* are different forms of the verb *be*.
>
> But, we say: I *go* home, I *have written* a letter.
>
> *Go* and *have written* are plural forms of the verbs *go* and *write*. So, in the present and present perfect tenses, *I* takes a plural verb when that verb is not the verb *be*.

In *(f)*, the subject *We* is first person plural. So, the verb is first person plural—*are singing*.

In *(g)*, the subject *He/She* is third person singular. So, the verb is third person singular—*sings*.

In *(h)*, the subject *They* is third person plural. So, the verb is third person plural—*sing*.

In *(i)*, the subject *You* is second person, which always takes a plural verb whether it denotes one or many persons. So the verb is plural—*sing*.

In *(j)*, the subject *Govinda* (proper noun) = a third person singular pronoun. So, the verb is third person singular—*sings*.

In *(k)*, the subject *birds* (common noun) = a third person plural pronoun. So, the verb is third person plural—*sing*.

In *(l)*, the subject *cat* (common noun) = a third person singular pronoun. So, the verb is third person singular—*mews*.

Note:

1. In the future perfect tense, which is formed with *will* and *shall,* the plural form *have* is used even when the subject is singular in number:
   (m) He/She/It will have sung.
   (n) They will have sung.
2. With collective nouns, we usually use singular verbs. Sometimes, however, plural verbs are also used.
   (o) The English team was defeated in the final match.
   (p) The crew of the ship were English and Australian.

   In *(o)*, the *English team*—a group—is thought of as a single unit. So, a singular verb is used.

   In *(p)*, each person belonging to the *crew*—a group—is being thought of separately or individually. The *crew*, therefore, does not remain a single unit anymore; the crew becomes many persons—Englishmen and Australians that it is made up of. So, a plural verb is used.

C ***Fill in the blanks with the correct forms of the verbs chosen from those given in brackets:***

1. The lady you met just now ..... (is/are) my mother's best friend.
2. Anyone, who ..... (wants/want) to win this prize, must attend school every day.

3. There ..... (is/are) no furniture in this room.
4. Does your dog ..... (bites/bite)?
5. The news of the imminent earthquake ..... (is/are) spreading fast.
6. Either Ishaan or you ..... (has/have) broken this jug.
7. Two hundred rupees ..... (is/are) a lot of money.
8. John, along with his brother, ... (goes/go) daily to the gymnasium.
9. My aunt or my uncle ..... (is/are) expected to attend the ceremony.
10. There ..... (was/were) a famous musician at the concert.

D ***Rewrite the following sentences, correcting the forms of the verbs wherever necessary:***

1. This group of students are going on an excursion.
2. Everyone blame Sohail whenever the class are punished.
3. Ronnie like reading mystery stories, I likes travelogues.
4. My friends has decided to go to Varanasi this winter.
5. My brother and the tall boy called Mihir is playing drums.
6. Though this dish look tempting, you must not eats it.
7. Mathematics are a difficult subject.
8. The people is celebrating their country's victory in the World Cup.
9. The children was laughing at the antics of the clown.
10. Where has all my friends gone? When am they coming back?
11. There is, in that room, twenty men ready to die for their country.
12. Does you not know what 'a score' mean?
13. No boy can runs faster than John.
14. He does not ever tells the truth.
15. He could sees a light in the distance.